

TRIPLE CROWN CHARGE

Multiple lead changes and a late-race twist couldn't stop Antonelli from sealing a third straight win and **extending** his championship lead.

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The more things change, the more they stay the same' — Jean-Baptiste Alphonse Karr's aphorism certainly holds for the return of F1 after a five-week recess.

The development battle was in full swing during the calendar gap following the cancellation of the Bahrain and Saudi Arabian races. **McLaren and Ferrari landed on the east coast of the United States with several upgrades in a bid to haul in the all-powerful Mercedes car.** But after a thrilling race that saw multiple changes for the lead, it was Kimi Antonelli who made it a hat-trick of wins in the top tier of single-seater racing to extend his drivers' championship lead.

A dramatic start, in a race that began three hours early due to thunderstorm warnings, handed Ferrari's Charles Leclerc the early lead after pole-sitter Antonelli and Red Bull's Max Verstappen went too wide into Turn 1 after locking up their tyres, allowing the Monegasque driver to surge through. Verstappen's poor start worsened after a spin on the opening lap dropped him down the

order. Antonelli, Leclerc and Lando Norris then exchanged positions, each taking the lead assisted by the 'overtake' feature, only to concede it back when the option opened for the trailing car.

Four-time champion Verstappen was handed a lifeline when the Safety Car was deployed following crashes for his current and former teammates, Isack Hadjar and Pierre Gasly. **The cheap pit stop and an early switch to hard tyres helped the Dutchman climb back up the order, culminating in a fifth-place finish despite a five-second penalty for a pit-exit line incursion.**

Norris, who had taken the Sprint win on Saturday but could only manage the second row after a four-team battle for pole, was the closest challenger to Antonelli after Leclerc's tyres faded, but could not muster a serious threat, finishing 3.2 seconds behind the Italian. Oscar Piastri, pointless after the first two races, earned his second successive podium, albeit 24 seconds behind his teammate.

Ferrari, expected to be a principal contender following the updated race machine, had a race to forget. Lewis Hamilton was involved in a wheel-to-wheel tussle with Franco Colapinto, sustaining front-wing damage that cost him significant downforce and any chance of fighting ahead.

Leclerc, who had gone toe-to-toe with the frontrunners for much of the race, unraveled on the final lap. The scarlet-red car tapped the wall, spun, cut across multiple chicanes and tussled with George Russell in a desperate attempt to hold position — actions not viewed kindly by the stewards. **The 28-year-old was handed a drive-through penalty, later converted into a 20-second post-race deduction, dropping him to eighth.**

Colapinto finished seventh, between the two Ferraris, for his best Grand Prix result. It was also a positive outing for Williams, which placed both cars in the points for the first time after a difficult start to the season.